

The First Real Deadline: The Second Attempt

第一个真实期限：第二次尝试

Theme: 求职、职场与职业发展 · New: 45 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 45/6, 127

English Story

The second attempt began with a **plan** on a **plastic desk** under a low **ceiling**. The **committee** had asked them to **perform** one **investigation** before they spent another month: could the **tool** be built without the **equipment** they did not have? "You must realize," the **landlord** said, "that the **smoke** alarm is the only thing in this building that always works."

The **advantage** of the small team was its **availability**: a **photographer**, a **lecturer**, a **retailer**, and a **chemist** were all free that week. Together they could **construct** a **demo** on a **desktop** in three days, and they could buy the **spare** parts from a **second hand vendor** in the **cave** of a market. "The face of the customer is the only specification that means anything," Maya said.

It would be a **promising performer**, this **tool**, if they could keep it honest. "A **composer**, a **robot**, and an **opera** singer all use the same **punch** card," she said. "The difference is what they do with the sound." They would spend the week on the **quantification** of something that could not be counted, and they would do it together.

The **competitive** pressure was **speculative** and therefore endless. A **coupon** in a cancelled **buffet**, a **fry** cook's **opener**, and the **notional** promise of a **hack** from a rival firm: all of it had to be folded into the **plan**. "You could say the software would evolve," Lin wrote, "but evolution is not **fiction**, and **cancellation** is not a strategy."

The **industrious** part was the **tireless** part. Today they counted what the **tool** did; tomorrow they would count what it failed to do. "The month is not the unit," she said. "The failure is." It was a mean way to put it, and it was also the only way that would keep them honest. The police had asked whether the **tool** would be available to everyone, and the answer was not yet available either. A small parade of questions followed: could a **second hand vendor** sell it, would the **committee** buy the **plan**, must they spend the month on the demonstration, and would they, together, be able to face the small print? They would, they said, and today they meant it.

中文翻译

第二次尝试从一张计划开始，放在低矮天花板下的一张塑料桌上。委员会要求他们在再花一个月之前先做一次调查：这件工具能否在没有那些他们并不拥有的设备的情况下造出来？“你必须意识到，”房东说，“这栋楼里唯一一直好用的东西就是烟雾报警器。”

小团队的优势在于可调配：一位摄影师、一位讲师、一位零售商和一位化学家那一周都有空。他们一起可以在三天内在一台台式机上搭出一个演示，并能从市场上一个洞穴般的二手摊贩那里买到备件。“客户的脸色是唯一真正有意义的规格说明，”曼雅说。

如果能让它保持诚实，这会是一件有前途的表演者。“一位作曲家、一个机器人和一位歌剧歌手用的是同一张打孔卡，”她说，“区别在于他们怎么处理声音。”他们会把这一周花在对某种无法计数之物的量化上，而且会一起做。

竞争压力是投机性的，因此没有尽头。一张被取消的自助餐的优惠券、一位油炸厨师的开门器，以及对手公司一次黑客行为的想象承诺：全都得折进计划里。“你可以说软件会进化，”林伟写道，“但进化不是虚构，而取消不是策略。”

勤勉的部分就是不知疲倦的部分。今天他们数这件工具做到了什么；明天他们要数它没能做到什么。“月份不是单位，”她说，“失败才是。”这样说是刻薄的，也是唯一能让他们保持诚实的说法。警察问过，这件工具是否会对所有人开放，而这个问题同样还没有答案。随后是一小串问题：二手商贩可以卖它吗？委员会会买这个方案吗？他们必须把这个月花在演示上吗？而他们一起，能面对那些小字条款吗？他们说能，而今天他们是当真的。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
plan plæn POS: n	n. 计划, 方案, 策略, 方法, 进度表, 程序表, 平面图, 设计图, 轮廓, 示意图; vt. 计划, 设计, 意欲; vi. 订计划 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a series of steps to be carried out or goals to be accomplished; n. scale drawing of a structure; v. have th...
committee ke'miti POS: n	n. 委员会; [经] 委员会 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a special group delegated to consider some matter; n. a self-constituted organization to promote something
realize 'riəlaiz POS: vt	vt. 了解, 实现, 使显得逼真, 变卖; vi. 变卖 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. make real or concrete; give reality or substance to; v. convert into cash; of goods and property; v. expand...
perform pe'fɔ:m POS: vt	vt. 进行, 履行, 完成, 执行, 表演; vi. 行动, 工作, 执行, 演出 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. carry out or perform an action; v. perform a function; v. give a performance (of something)
advantage əd'vɑ:ntɪdʒ POS: n	n. 优点, 便利, 好处, 优势; vt. 有助于 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the quality of having a superior or more favorable position; n. (tennis) first point scored after deuce; n. ...
equipment i'kwɪpmənt POS: n	n. 装备, 设备, 才能; [化] 设备; 装备; 装置 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an instrumentality needed for an undertaking or to perform a service
investigation in.ves'ti'geɪʃən POS: n	n. 调查, 审查; [医] 调查, 调查研究 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the work of inquiring into something thoroughly and systematically
tool tu:l POS: n	n. 工具, 机床, 傀儡; vt. 用工具加工; vi. 使用工具 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an implement used in the practice of a vocation; v. drive; v. furnish with tools; v. work with a tool
plastic 'plæstɪk POS: n	n. 塑料, 可塑体, 可塑性物质; a. 塑料的, 塑造的, 有可塑性的, 造型的, 易受影响的, 有创造力的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. generic name for certain synthetic or semisynthetic materials that can be molded or extruded into objects...
desk desk POS: n	n. 书桌, 办公桌, 工作台 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a piece of furniture with a writing surface and usually drawers or other compartments
construct kən'strʌkt POS: vt	vt. 构造, 建造, 对...进行构思, 作图; n. 构成物 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. make by combining materials and parts; v. draw with suitable instruments and under specified conditions; v. ...
competitive kəm'petɪtɪv POS: a	a. 竞争的; [经] 竞争的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. involving competition or competitiveness; s. subscribing to capitalistic competition; s. showing a fighting...
smoke sməʊk POS: n	n. 烟, 雾气, 烟熏剂, 抽烟, 烟色; vi. 吸烟, 冒烟, 弥漫; vt. 以烟熏, 抽烟而导致... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a cloud of fine particles suspended in a gas; n. a hot vapor containing fine particles of carbon being prod...
landlord 'lændlɔ:d POS: n	n. 房东, 地主; [经] 业主, 地主, 房东 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a landowner who leases to others
ceiling 'si:lɪŋ POS: n	n. 天花板; [经] 顶点, 顶线, 上限 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the overhead upper surface of a covered space; n. (meteorology) altitude of the lowest layer of clouds; n. a...
fiction 'fɪkʃən POS: n	n. 小说, 虚构故事; [法] 虚构的事实, 捏造, 拟制 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a literary work based on the imagination and not necessarily on fact
evolve i'vɒlv POS: vi	vi. 进展, 进化, 展开; vt. 使发展, 使推断出, 使进化 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. work out; v. undergo development or evolution
opera 'ɒpərə POS: n	n. 歌剧 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a drama set to music; consists of singing with orchestral accompaniment and an orchestral overture and int...
photographer fə'tɒ'refə POS: n	n. 摄影师, 摄影者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone who takes photographs professionally
vendor 'vendə POS: n	n. 小贩, 卖主, 自动售货机; [计] 计算机销售商 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n someone who promotes or exchanges goods or services for money
cave keɪv POS: n	n. 洞, 穴; vi. 凹陷, 塌落; vt. 挖洞, 使凹陷, 损坏...的基础 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a geological formation consisting of an underground enclosure with access from the surface of the ground o...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
spare speə POS: n	n. 剩余, 备用品, 备件, 备用零件, 备用轮胎; a. 多余的, 备用的, 空闲的, 节约的, 瘦的; vi. 节约, 省掉, 宽恕; v... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a score in tenpins; knocking down all ten after rolling two balls; v. refrain from harming; v. save or relieve...
availability əˌveɪlə'bɪlɪti POS: n	n. 有效性, 可利用性, 可利用的人; [计] 有效性; 可用性 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n the quality of being at hand when needed
promising 'promɪʃɪŋ POS: a	a. 有希望的, 前途有望的; [经] 有希望的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. showing possibility of achievement or excellence
performer pə'fɔ:mə POS: n	n. 表演者, 执行者, 完成者; [法] 执行者, 履行者, 实行者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an entertainer who performs a dramatic or musical work for an audience
punch pʌntʃ POS: n	n. 打洞器, 钻孔机, 冲压机, 冲床, 潘趣酒; vt. 以拳重击, 开洞, 冲压; vi. 用拳猛击 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (boxing) a blow with the fist; n. an iced mixed drink usually containing alcohol and prepared for multiple...
composer kəm'pəʊzə POS: n	n. 作曲家, 作家, 调停者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone who composes music as a profession
desktop 'deskɒp POS: n	n. 桌面; [计] 桌面 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the top of a desk
lecturer 'lektʃərə POS: n	n. 演讲者, 讲师; [法] 讲演人, 讲课人, 讲师 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone who lectures professionally
retailer 'ri:teɪlə POS: n	n. 零售商人, 传播的人; [经] 零售商 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a merchant who sells goods at retail
robot 'rəʊbət POS: n	n. 机械人, 自动机械, 机械般工作的人; [计] 机器人; 自动机 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a mechanism that can move automatically
chemist 'kemɪst POS: n	n. 化学家, 药剂师; [化] 化学家; 化学师; 化学工作者; 药剂师; 药房 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a scientist who specializes in chemistry
coupon 'ku:pɒn POS: n	n. 息票, 赠券; [经] 息票, 利息单, 联票 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a negotiable certificate that can be detached and redeemed as needed; n. a test sample of some substance
speculative ˈspekjʊleɪtɪv POS: a	a. 思索性的, 投机的, 推测的; [经] 投机的, 冒险的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s not financially safe or secure; s not based on fact or investigation; s showing curiosity
fry fraɪ POS: n	n. 油炸食物, 鱼苗; v. 油炸, 煎 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. English painter and art critic (1866-1934); n. English dramatist noted for his comic verse dramas (born 190...
opener 'əʊpənə POS: n	n. 开...的人, 开局人, 开创人, 开具, 开启工具, 首项; [经] 申请开证人 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the first event in a series; n. a hand tool used for opening sealed containers (bottles or cans)
buffet 'bʌfɪt POS: n	n. 自助餐, 小卖部, 碗橱, 殴打, 冲击; vt. 连续打, 冲击, 搏斗; vi. 奋斗 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a piece of furniture that stands at the side of a dining room; has shelves and drawers; n. a meal set out o...
cancellation kænsə'leɪʃən POS: n	n. 取消, 作废, 注销戳; [经] 注销, 取消, 保险单的注销 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of cancelling; calling off some arrangement; n. the speech act of revoking or annulling or making v...
hack hæk POS: n	n. 劈, 砍, 砍痕, 出租车, 干咳, 晒架, 鹤嘴锄; vt. 劈, 砍, 出租, 用旧; vi. 劈, 砍, 干咳, 驾驶出租车; a... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. one who works hard at boring tasks; n. a mediocre and disdained writer; n. a tool (as a hoe or pick or matto...
demo 'deməʊ POS: n	n. 演示, 样本唱片; [计] 演示 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a visual presentation showing how something works; v give an exhibition of to an interested audience
notional 'nəʊʃənəl POS: a	a. 概念的, 想像的; [经] 名义上的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. not based on fact or investigation
tireless 'taɪəlɪs POS: a	a. 不疲倦的, 不厌倦的, 不屈不挠的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s showing sustained enthusiastic action with unflagging vitality; s characterized by hard work and perseverance
quantification ,kwɒntɪfɪ'keɪʃ(ə)n POS: review required	[计] 量化, 定量; [经] 定量比率 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a limitation imposed on the variables of a proposition (as by the quantifiers 'some' or 'all' or 'no'); n. ...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
industrious in'dastriəs POS: a	a. 勤勉的, 刻苦的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s characterized by hard work and perseverance; s working hard to promote an enterprise
second hand phonetic unavailable POS: review required	中间人, 助手; [经] 旧货 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: No reliable source example available.